

What the Eastern Orthodox Church ACTUALLY Teaches (w/ Fr Seraphim Holland)

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From the **Reformed Pastor** @ReformedPastorclips

This transcript:

<http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/what-the-eastern-orthodox-actually-teaches-podcast-2026-03-05.pdf>

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VIDEO: <https://youtu.be/OmzxTvhQUsA?si=zY6s7U1CG-TpWNO>

From Daniel's YouTube Description: In this video I have a conversation with Fr Seraphim about Orthodoxy. We discuss salvation, works, grace, Mariology, iconography, the church and the eucharist. The purpose of this video is not to change minds. It's to better understand one another for gospel clarity.

[00:00](#) Introduction

[02:30](#) Why Orthodoxy?

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Please note: this is a conversation between Daniel, a pastor in the Reformed Christian tradition and Priest Seraphim Holland, an Eastern Orthodox priest. It may be confusing who is talking, but, the vast majority of the time, all questions are from Daniel. You will get the gist after a little bit of reading.

The following transcript is slightly edited (preserving all meaning). It may have mistakes, but reading it may be easier for many than listening to this very cordial and interesting conversation.

I think many subjects will serve as a catechesis about Orthodox doctrine and practice, to be accepted, or rejected by the listener/reader.

This was a very enjoyable conversation. Daniel and I certainly did not always agree, and we also often agreed, and we had a lot of fun. There was laughter and there is little bit of joking and mutual respect, and I think there was a real conversation about differing opinions.

Priest Seraphim Holland

Here is a table of contents, which more or less conforms to Daniel’s timestamps.

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Hey guys, welcome to the channel. Today we have a really, really special episode.

I have the huge pleasure of welcoming Father Seraphim. Father Seraphim, thanks so much for joining today. I really appreciate it.

“I’m glad to be here.”

So, a number of weeks ago—I made, it might have been a couple of months ago now—I made a video on three reasons why I’m not Eastern Orthodox. And the comment section was pretty stacked.

A few people, a few of the Orthodox people, were saying that rather than me just giving my opinion on what the Orthodox believe, I should have a priest on to talk, so that way you can sort of steelman one another’s positions rather than straw-man them. And I said in the comment section that I would do that, and so I guess this is kind of a way of me fulfilling what I said there. And why, Father?

“So I’m the man of steel, huh?”

[laughter]

“Okay. I’m the man of steel.”

And the reason for Father Seraphim is, well, he’s super gracious. His stuff is really, really helpful, and I’ve benefited immensely from various videos I’ve seen online as well. So yeah. Again, thanks, Father, for joining.

What drew you to Eastern Orthodoxy? Have you always been Orthodox?

Can I begin with this question? What drew you to Eastern Orthodoxy? Have you always been Orthodox?

“No. No.”

“Yeah.” “I was raised Roman Catholic, and I was born in ’58, so I’m an old fat guy. And Vatican II happened, I believe, in ’62. And my mother comes to me after a few years and says, ‘Oh, you know, you don’t have to fast anymore because you’re less than 16. And the magisterium has said that you don’t have to fast until you’re 16.’

“And I thought that was the dumbest thing of all time. I didn’t know at the time that they’d already gutted fasting, because all we had was Fish Friday, right? We didn’t eat meat on Friday. We ate everything else, but we didn’t eat meat. And that was a big ascetical endeavor. And I thought, ‘Okay, we don’t eat meat. That’s cool.’ And when she wanted to change it, I thought that was just stupid. And that was the beginning of the end for me. I didn’t really like that, the way I was raised.

“My dad believed in the man upstairs, you know. He just believed in God, but not really particularly anything, you know. He taught me everything I know about being a man until I became an Orthodox Christian. So I owe a great debt to him. But religiously it just wasn’t a significant thing to him, you know.”

“So I rejected Roman Catholicism when I was still young, and I would be watching the old Star Trek reruns on TV while my dad was cooking breakfast and my mother went to Mass, and then she’d come back and we’d have breakfast. So those are my memories of early Catholicism. I just rejected it because there was very little emphasis on Christ. There was an incredible emphasis on the pope. It just seemed very shallow to me, very legalistic to me. There was no ‘there’ there. That’s a famous quote of W. C. Fields when he referred to Cleveland. He said, ‘There’s no there there.’ So there was nothing to bite into. And so I rejected it.

“I went to college, was looking for purpose in life, as I thought every young man in the entire Universe did. But I’ve learned that that’s not true. Not every person looks for purpose in their life. A lot of people, most people, just kind of go through life. Whatever happens, happens, and they have their desires and they have this and they have that, and they might be a good person, a bad person, but they don’t really have an eternal goal. You know, they just think God’s up there, God loves me, I’m going to heaven, and that’s about it. Of course nowadays people don’t even care that much, right?

“And so I had a desire to fulfill my purpose, and I thought, okay, my purpose must be to do something good in the world, right, to leave the world a better place. I wanted to become a heart surgeon, and I was getting good grades and everything, so I was on track for that. But that just didn’t seem to—I don’t know, it didn’t track with me, because I thought, okay, I’m going to help a person with a bad heart, and they’re going to die 20 years later, 30 years later, 80 years later. I’m going to be the greatest heart surgeon of all time, and my people are going to live 60 years after each heart transplant, and they’re all going to die. So it’s all temporary. I hate temporary things.

“So I thought, what’s eternal? I was doing research. I was in biochemistry, and I was doing research between my sophomore and my junior year at the university. I was terrible at the research, but I was rooming with a guy

called Navigators. I don't know if you've heard of them. I don't know if they're in the UK, but they're kind of a Protestant parachurch organization.

"Okay."

"Which is a strange term, but they have their typical kind of Roman Road kind of theology, kind of substitutionary atonement theology and everything like that. Not Calvinism, but, you know, evangelical Protestants, okay? And he was just calm and sweet and good. And I think he gave me a Bible. I came home and I had that sort of experience of a spiritual change where I asked Jesus Christ into my heart.

"But at the time I was asking Him into my heart because He would forgive my sins, because He took all my sins on the Cross and the wrath of the Father is appeased by that act, and therefore I would be saved. And I made a lot of changes. I mean, I started attending a local Campus Crusade place and preaching to people and all that stuff. But it really bothered me that so many beliefs were just accepted. There was a cacophony of beliefs. We believe in Jesus. We don't really talk about if He has two natures or if He has one nature, if He has one will, two wills. We don't really talk about any of that stuff, but we do talk about that we believe in Jesus. He's the Son of God. He died on the cross for our sins.

"And that was about the only thing that we had in common. Baptism—yeah, different beliefs about baptism. Most people believed that baptism was symbolic of your belief, sort of like renewing your vows in your marriage. You're already married, but you're showing the world that you love each other. And other people believed, of course, baptism was—I didn't have the Orthodox doctrine about it—but more or less that baptism is necessary for salvation. Then there's the Eucharist. A lot of people didn't believe at all about the Eucharist. They thought it was just a commemoration. And other people said, 'Well, we don't do that at all.' Etc., etc.

"I mean, there's all things. Mary the Theotokos. Oh my gosh. You know, there's basically one belief about that: that she was just a Jewish woman that happened to give birth to Jesus Christ and then she went on being a mother, you know, which was weird to me. And all these other beliefs. Everybody had all this cacophony of beliefs, but we're all brothers and sisters in Christ. And that didn't make sense to me because the Scripture says that I will send you the Holy Spirit, the Comforter, who will lead you into all truth. I thought, where's the all truth?

"So I happened to meet my wife, who was being a bad Orthodox [laughter] and going to Campus Crusade for Christ meetings because she was brought up in kind of an ecumenical spirit and she didn't really know the difference. All she knew was that she made the sign of the cross and she ate lamb on Pascha, you know. But I was smitten by her. So we started dating and I said, 'Let's go to your church in Indianapolis.'

"And then we go to an Orthodox church, and" "it was just a regular Vespers service, an evening service. And of course we have lots of responsorial litanies like, 'In peace let us pray to the Lord. Lord, have mercy.' And I was absolutely completely blown away by 'Lord, have mercy,' because basically among my peers it was all like, we have mercy. God gave us mercy. We were supposed to die. We were supposed to go to hell. God has given us mercy by dying on the Cross for us. And there was not really this idea of mercy other than that it's not to judge someone, right? I mean, there was an idea that God protects us, etc., etc., but really it wasn't

emphasized. Mercy was: you got mercy. Some people said you can't lose your salvation. Some people said you could. They were the weird ones. Etc., etc.

"And so when I heard, 'Lord, have mercy,' something in my heart just absolutely said, this is right. These people have got it right. So I was a college student. So what did I do? I checked out books. I read them. I read *The Orthodox Church* by Timothy Ware, later Kallistos Ware, one of your own from the UK. And I read a bunch of other books. I got ahold of a prayer book, the so-called Jordanville Prayer Book, which is kind of a standard among Orthodox English-speaking people.

"And I just went on a mission to New Jersey and was preaching on the beaches to people. And as I was preaching, I was no longer believing what I was preaching. I was believing what is Orthodox. So they had trouble with me because the last two weeks I wouldn't go to meetings and I wouldn't pray with them. I just couldn't. I was out. I was in between.

"And then when I got back to the university for my—that would have been for my senior year—then I pursued becoming an Orthodox Christian and became a catechumen and was baptized. I insisted on being baptized. My priest wanted to chrismate me already. Back then I was stubborn, and here I am.

"But the reason I'm Orthodox is because Orthodoxy is beautiful. I mean, Orthodoxy is beautiful. I didn't find beauty in Roman Catholicism. I didn't find beauty in going to some Baptist or evangelical church or even some charismatic church. What do they do? They have some announcements. They have some songs. If they're charismatic, they put their hands in the air. Otherwise, you know, and then a sermon and then some more announcements and some more songs, and that's it. There was nothing that was beautiful. It didn't matter what time of year it was, that was it, okay? A little bit about Christmas, a little bit about Easter, but really only on the day of Easter, which I call Pascha, maybe the day of Christmas or maybe if they're leading up to Christmas. I just couldn't stand it. It wasn't beautiful. Orthodoxy is beautiful. Absolutely beautiful. Everything about it just fits human nature like a glove. Just absolutely wonderful.

"And then I learned from Orthodox ascetical theology what the real purpose of life is, right? You might know of the Westminster Catechism. You know about that? You must know that."

"Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. Yeah."

"What's the first thing? What's the first thing? Number one?"

"The chief end of man: to glorify God and enjoy Him forever."

"Exactly. And we say, 'No, it's not to glorify God. It doesn't end near glory.' The chief end of man is to have union with God. So you say, 'Enjoy Him forever.' Okay, I get it. But for us, it's much more intense. It's like the whole purpose of your life is for the image of God, which every man has, right, because we're made in the image of God, to become His likeness. Because that's what it says in Genesis: 'Let us make man according to Our image and according to Our likeness,' which is an archaic way of saying so that he can become like Us. Right?"

"Sure."

"And we cannot know someone unless we become like them. So for us salvation is becoming like God, not being saved from hell."

"Yeah. I think you're definitely putting your finger on one of the weaknesses of modern evangelicalism. That's for sure. I've tried to say recently that salvation is so much more exciting than just, you're not going to hell when

you die. Salvation ultimately, even for Calvin, is union with Christ. Calvin in the Institutes says something so beautiful when he said that if Christ was far off from us, everything He did for the salvation of the human race remains of no avail to us. You need to be engrafted into Christ. There needs to be this wonderful union. And so, yeah, salvation is participation in the Triune God, isn't it? Now, obviously, the way that we would understand that would be slightly different. I do love that emphasis and I really do appreciate that.

"So, some people claim that Orthodoxy is a religion of works and doesn't have room for grace. I'd love you to speak into that. So, I guess just personally, in some of my interactions online—I don't know if you see this, Father Seraphim—whenever I'm engaging with what are called orthobros, I don't even know if you know that that's a thing."

"Yeah, I know about the orthobros."

"And, you know, it doesn't matter how much I say, you know, Christ is so gracious, so wonderful, so merciful. He has more grace than you have sin. Whenever I'm interacting with [or bros] ortho bros, it always seems to be, oh, but no, don't forget this though. We need to do stuff—as if, you know, I don't believe in good works too. And so, I'm not sure if that's a fair representation. Like, obviously the ortho bros aren't going to be a fair representation of Orthodox theology. Obviously, I'm not that silly, right?

What is salvation for the Orthodox Church? Can you save yourself?

So, what is salvation for the Orthodox Church? Can you save yourself? Can you speak into that? Is that all right?"

"Yes. You absolutely cannot save yourself. I mean, we're saved by grace. That's pretty clear. And we're saved because of—well, primarily, because God is, right? God is who He is. He made us according to His will and His plan, and God can do anything He wants. So, God saves us.

"But the mechanism by which He saves us is that Jesus, the Son of God, Only-begotten of the Father, begotten before all ages, Light of Light, true God of true God—the eternal God became man in time. And now Jesus Christ is eternally God and man, two natures that are joined together but not mixed. And then He lived the perfect human life and did not sin and paved the way for our nature to become changed through baptism, and then for us to have the ability to become perfected, and then to know the One who is perfect, to participate in His energies, in His life, in His grace.

"And He made it possible because He did that as the first perfect human being, right? As the second Adam. So, for us, it's all about the Incarnation and becoming like God. And you know, the verse says it in Colossians—I don't remember where—that we are according to the measure and stature of Jesus Christ. So, by this definition of humanity, you and I are not humans yet, right? We're not fully human. To be fully human is to know God and to have nothing but God in our heart, right? To be complete vessels of the Holy Spirit, to have no darkness in us whatsoever, and to easily do what is right and to easily not even desire to do what is wrong, much less do it. So, this is a transformation that occurs over temporal human life, leading us to eternity.

“So right now you and I are eternal beings—or maybe, if you want to be technical about it, everlasting beings, right? Because we began in time, but now we don’t end, right? We’re completely eternal. I mean, the good guys, the bad guys, everybody’s eternal, right? And for us salvation is perfection.

“Now, how do you get perfect? I mean, how do you get good at playing guitar? By practicing, or talking to people who are good at guitar, right? How do you get good at being humble? Well, by being humbled. How do you learn to love? By loving, right? So, for us, it’s not works. It’s a reaction. Just like, is it works for the flower to grow toward the light? No. It’s natural for the flower. It’s called geotropism, right? It grows toward the light.”
“We grow toward the Light. So, for us, it’s not that we must do works, it’s that we won’t be saved without works because the whole point is perfection.

“So, if you have a baby—go ahead.”

“No, I was just going to ask it. No, you give your illustration, then I’ll ask a question.”

“So, if you have a baby, you have a child, and you love this child, the child’s so cute, everything’s beautiful, but you do not train the child. You don’t talk to the child, or you just sit the kid in front of the TV or whatever. Well, there are studies: kids who watch hours and hours and hours of television have poor vocabularies, have poor impulse control, etc., etc., right? So that child could have been perfect. That child could have been incredible, but you didn’t teach him, right? So, the child had all the potential to be a great artist, to be a beautiful person, but that opportunity was squandered by the parents, right? And what parent would do that?”

“Unfortunately, a lot of them do. But a good parent wants to put of themselves into the child, right?”

“And that’s what God wants to do to us. He wants to give of Himself to us.”

“Sure. The way the Reformed understand this would be—and again, I found Calvin really helpful here—that you cannot sever justification and sanctification. They’re both found in union with Christ. But there is a sense, even with reading Cyril of Alexandria on his commentary on the Gospel of John—which by the way is just the greatest commentary on John—I don’t know if you’ve read Cyril on John.”

“I have not. I didn’t know it existed. Is it in Ancient Christian Commentary or something?”

“It’s on the Ancient Patristic Commentary series.”

“Oh really? Okay. Okay.”

“Yeah. But even in there, Cyril will use the language of justification by faith alone and not works. And it seems like even Cyril seems to be able to make a distinction between justification and sanctification. And I wonder if sometimes this is where we can be like ships passing by. I would just love greater clarity there. So, we would say that you would agree that Christ is our righteousness Himself. So, we’re united to Him by the Holy Spirit, and so we receive the righteousness of Christ on our behalf, but also the Christ who we’re united to makes us holy until perfection. Would you agree with that? How would you understand that?”

“Yes, I agree with it. I guess I might say it just slightly differently, but yes. I mean, all of our goodness comes from God. I mean, all good comes down from heaven, the Father of lights, right? So of course. We don’t do good in and of ourselves. But we love Him because He first loved us, right? But when God is within the heart, there is this desire within the heart. There’s this even compulsion within the heart. Not a self-compulsion, I mean totally free, okay? If you compel yourself, you’re free, right? If I say I need to get up at four in the morning to get my

work done, I'm saying I'm going to do that and I'm going to force myself to do that, but nobody else is forcing me. So, I consider that a free act."

"Right. Sure."

"And we're free in our hearts to love God and then to do the things that a person who loves God would do: love our neighbor, pray, help our neighbor, have a desire to read the Scriptures—everything. All of it, every good work, is because we love God, right? And we react to Him. That's it. The whole point of life is to become perfected. It's not to not go to hell, like you said. I agree with that. That sounds terrible. I mean, that doesn't sound very interesting at all. What's the point of all of this if that's just the goal, right?"

"Exactly. Well, if you don't go to hell, but you're still a sinner, what good are you, right?"

"See, I mean, there are no sinners in heaven. There's a change that occurs. Now obviously, most of that change is going to occur at the last trump, right? Because we're still going to have all our problems until the day we die. But we're getting better, and there's a desire in our heart to change. But imagine—I can't imagine being a sinner and being a forgiven sinner. That sounds terrible. I want to be a non-sinner." [laughter]

"Oh yeah, me too. Would you agree with the 'simultaneously just and sinner'? There is a sense in which we are, you know, like the Apostle Paul even in 1 Timothy 1:15 is able to say he's a sinner. Would you agree with that paradigm, that we are righteous in Christ and you're becoming more holy and also, we're still riddled with sin?"

"Of course. What does St. Paul say? I think it's in chapter 7 of Romans, right? 'That what I do, I don't do. That what I don't want to do I do.' I mean, this is St. Paul talking here, right? The other one who said, 'I've completed the course,' that was at the end of his life, right? That wasn't in the middle. Of course, we're sinners, but we're also righteous. We are so unique as a spiritual being that we are capable of doing the ghastliest things and turning around a moment later and doing something that's magnificent."

"Yeah, I agree."

"Yeah, thanks. That's helpful."

Iconography

So, one of the other big differences would be iconography. So personally, I don't have a problem with iconography. I'm not an iconoclast. I could happily go through a beautiful building and enjoy icons or walk through the Sistine Chapel and enjoy Michelangelo's art. That doesn't bother me. But I guess I wouldn't call myself an iconophile. I feel uncomfortable venerating or kissing or bowing down to an icon. What can you tell us the meaning behind that? And is it true that if I don't kiss an icon, am I under a curse? I'd love your thoughts on that.

"No, you're not under a curse. You're not under a curse. Icons are a representation that the Incarnation happened because Jesus Christ is fully man. Therefore, you can paint Him, you can stab a sword through Him, you can beat Him, you can put Him on a cross and He will die. He gets sleepy and sleeps in a boat like Jonah.

You could take a photograph of Him if you had such technology, right? He's fully a man, and so we can represent Him.

"And really the seminal event in the salvation of man is not the creation of man—and you could argue that, okay, I'm fine if you say that—it is the Incarnation, because the Incarnation makes man able [to come to God can come to man all he wants]—God can come to man all He wants, and He does—but man cannot appropriate God, cannot understand God, until he is a changed being. And that's what we believe happens in baptism. You know, not circumcision or uncircumcision or anything, but a new creature.

"And icons are all that is in iconography, and we're depicting Jesus Christ. And there's a spirit of reverence that I've never understood to be present anywhere else except Orthodoxy, this incredible reverence for holy things. I understand people reverence holy things. I get that. But it's just different in Orthodoxy. It's just different. And we have icons. We kiss the icons. We're not confused. We don't think the icon is the person. We don't think the icon is, you know, a part of the Trinity or any—we don't worship the icon, but we have great reverence for the icon.

"And a person who doesn't kiss icons—well, all right. Live and let live. I'm not going to judge people. God will judge everybody. I don't have any concern about that. It's not, as we say in Texas, I don't have a dog in this fight, you know. It's not for me to decide."

"Yeah. Sure. What would you say to those who—and I'm not one of them—you know, I guess what's the technical term? iconophile."

"I don't know that term. I don't know that term."

"It's sort of like I wouldn't destroy icons. I could enjoy them, but I wouldn't venerate. I think there's something in the middle. So, I'm not one of the people that would say this, but how would you respond to someone that would say it's a breaking of the first and second commandments if you paint an image of Jesus or whatever? What would be a good response?"

"Well, I would say, why did Jesus tell them to bow down before an image of a snake, which represents Jesus on the cross? He told them to venerate the snake that was on the pole. Otherwise, they would die of snakebite. Also, the cherubim were in the [high place] holy place, right? They were images. These iconoclastic Jews had images. So, we have to explain that. We have to be able to explain that.

"What was the exact question that you said?"

"How would you respond to those who would say you're making an idol if you try to depict Jesus in art?"

"Oh, okay. Well, I mean, like I said, those two things—are those idols? Did God tell them to do idols? An idol is when you're worshipping something that is not God, right? So, your idol could be money, your idol could be, I don't know, Ganesha, your idol could just be something, right? But we're not worshipping icons. Icons bring us to worship God. It's a completely different paradigm. It doesn't even occur to us that it's any kind of worship.

"But for people looking on the outside, it's just like that canard about 'call no man father.' I mean, people have the dumbest interpretation of that. It's just so stupid. Paul says—you know, Jesus says— 'Call no man father,' and then Paul later on says, 'I am your father in Christ.'"

"Yeah."

“Because I’ve begotten you. And then other times he says, ‘Brethren and fathers,’ when he addresses people. I mean, give me a break. ‘Call no man father.’ I mean, that is so infantile, to interpret that verse as saying we can’t say father. You know, give me a break.

“So, in the same way, it’s not idolatry to venerate an icon. It would be idolatry. There were things that people did that were excesses because if there’s something stupid that can be done, somebody’s going to do it, right? That’s a human law, right? That’s a constant. So, there were people that would take pieces of the icon and chip it away and they’d add it to the Eucharist to give it more power.”

“Oh wow.”

“Obviously that’s wrong, right? And the Church actually wrote canons: don’t do that.”

“Right. Yeah.”

“Right. I mean, but no, venerating icons brings us to Christ. The honor” “to the type passes to the prototype, right? So, if you’re venerating an icon of St. Basil, you’re remembering the works of St. Basil and you’re saying the effective and fervent prayer of a righteous man availeth much. And you’re saying, ‘St. Basil, pray for me.’”

“Do you think there’s a possible danger with it? I guess you kind of already answered that then.”

“Yeah. Yeah. Of course, there’s a possible danger with everything, right? Anything that can be abused will be. Anything that can be misinterpreted will be. We’ve learned that especially from the internet. Now, even things that can’t be misinterpreted are, because of the internet.”

“Right. Yeah.”

“So of course. People do stupid things and people do sinful things. And if you look at the history of the Church anywhere, whether it’s the Orthodox Church or anything else, you see people doing stupid things and terrible things and very unrighteous things, but the core is holy.”

Mariology

I put out a video and mentioned my concerns with the Akathist to Mary. Can I read a couple of the lines that caused me some concern? I’d love to hear your thoughts on that.

“Sure. Sure. By the way, I looked all over the place for that. I couldn’t find it. I really did. I looked all over. So, you have to send me the link to your YouTube site. I assume it’s on YouTube. I couldn’t find it.”

So, there are a couple of lines there. I’ll just rattle through a couple of them. This is to Mary:

“Rejoice, for through thee the curse shall cease. Rejoice, for through thee the creation is made new.”

Then secondly:

“You are the acceptable incense of intercession, the propitiation for the whole world.”

And then:

“You are the forgiveness for many who have stumbled.”

And then there was one prayer—I don’t think this was in the Akathist hymn, but it was in some sort of Orthodox prayer that I’d found that was liturgical, not just some random ortho bro—that said to Mary:

"Tear up the record of my many sins. Reconcile me to God. Make me worthy to stand. Deliver me from the eternal torments."

What are your thoughts on that? Can you see why, as a Reformed guy, that might make me shudder a little bit?

"Yeah, I get it. I get it. Let's do the first two. Read the first two because those are really easy. Those are softball questions. The first—"

"Yeah. The three I understand. But—"

"So, rejoice, for through thee the curse shall cease. Rejoice, for through thee the creation is made new."

"Okay. So obviously when we think of the Theotokos, we always think of the Incarnation. We don't really think of Mary without Christ."

"Mhm."

"And we know that the Theotokos intercedes for us. And we have hundreds of thousands probably of stories—many of them written down, but many of them just preserved locally—of the intercession of the Theotokos for groups of people, for countries, for one person, etc., etc."

"So, we know that she's very close to God and that she is a great intercessor." "And that she's constantly praying for us to her Son. That's where her power comes from. I mean, her power is by praying to God. That's always the case with all the saints, right? No saint can do anything of his own."

"We have a doctrine, a dogma, that demons cannot read your thoughts, right? Demons cannot read your thoughts. People are afraid that demons can, but that's not true. Demons cannot read your thoughts. Neither can an angel. Neither can anybody. However, saints or angels can know your thoughts because God reveals them to them, right? But nobody can know thoughts except God alone. Only God."

"And the Theotokos is very close to God. And therefore, the prayers of many are revealed to her in some mystical way we don't understand. Somehow the soul is able to understand much, much more than when it's in the body, right? It has vision. It has memory. It has hearing, shall we say? But it's able to see and hear and know infinitely more than we know now."

"I mean, if there are ten people talking to you, you might be able to make out one of them. Can you imagine ten million people talking to you? You wouldn't understand any of them. But in spiritual ways we can, right? Because God reveals it."

"And this language that's used is hyperbolic. So much of Hebrew poetry is very hyperbolic, right? It has God crushing people. It has all these things. And then Byzantine poetry is hyperbolic. So, to me I read it in a hyperbolic sense, not in a literal sense that she is our salvation. She's not our salvation. But she is the way in which our salvation came to earth."

"Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. Okay."

"So, it's a different mentality in terms of how we pray. We pray very ecstatically and we pray very hyperbolically, and we're just used to it. It's not a problem. But in the West, everything has to be divided up just perfectly. And I can understand why it sounded weird."

"I had trouble at the very beginning with Orthodoxy coming from Roman Catholicism. I couldn't stand the way they talked about the Mother of God." "I thought it was just kind of smarmy, and I didn't like it at all. And so,

then I get Orthodox prayers and I go, 'Oh, they're prayers of the Mother of God.' And I had that prejudice. It even took me years after baptism not to overcome the prejudice but to actually love the Theotokos with all of my heart and ask her intercessions.

"What really changed it for me is we have this custom of the Jesus Prayer: 'Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy on me.' And this is said by monks thousands of times. It's said by them when they're doing anything. And it should be said by lay people too. And it's really the easiest way to pray intensely to God.

"Well, these monks who are all about, shall we say—put it in a colloquial way—all about Jesus, they also are always going, 'O Panagia, All-Holy.' And they're always referring to the Mother of God, and they're always showing great reverence for her.

"These are men's men, right? I mean monks are hardcore. And yet they all love the Mother of God. To me that's why, okay—if they're hardcore about saying the Jesus Prayer and about praying the Psalter and about guarding the dogmas of the Holy Trinity, and they love the Mother of God, then there must be something there."

"Yeah. I mean, I'm absolutely all for loving and honoring the Theotokos, certainly more than a lot of my evangelical brothers and sisters do, right? I mean, a lot of them would deny that Mary is the Theotokos. I've had debates with them about that before, which obviously ends up either in Arian heresy or Nestorian heresy."

"Exactly. Exactly."

"You have to affirm that Mary is the Theotokos. But then it's sort of like, can we ascribe salvific predicates to Mary liturgically? That's kind of where I get a little bit, I guess, unstuck."

"I understand your reticence about it. I get it, and I appreciate your respectfulness in expressing this."

The truth

"It's just a different culture. Eastern culture is really different than Western culture. I feel like a stranger in a strange land. It's just different.

"I live in America. I've grown up in America. Therefore, I'm a child of the West. And yet the West seems strange to me. And our way of expressing ourselves in prayer is just so perfect to me.

"I understand your reticence, but I would say that what I did about my reticence was exactly this. I said, 'Okay, the Holy Spirit is going to lead us into all truth.' That's dogma.' Okay. Is there all truth right now among everybody that purports to be a Christian? Well, no. Clearly not. People are believing things that are contradictory.

"We talked about the Eucharist or baptism or Mary—all these contradictory beliefs. So, it's not possible to have contradictory beliefs if there is only truth. So where is the truth?

"Well, the truth is in the Church.

"And then where is the Church?

“Well, the Church I learned partially by work—by checking out books and reading them and such—and also just by God inspiring me, by God visiting me, that the Church is the holy Orthodox Church.

“Now, if the Church is true, then what the Church says is true. Not individual people within the Church, but the doctrine of the Church is true. The phronema, the mind of the Church, is true.

“And if that’s the case, then that’s how I evaluate everything. Should we pray to the Theotokos? Yes, because the Church does it. Should we fast? Yes, because the Church does it. Do we pray for the dead? Yes, because the Church does it. Really, it’s as simple as that. If the Church is true, then what the Church teaches and what the Church does—the core of what the Church is—is true. And that’s how I would evaluate it.

“So, I understand your reticence and I respect it. The only way that you would really be rid of that reticence is if you were to become a baptized Orthodox Christian, and over the course of time grace would just make you understand it.”

“Okay. Is there sort of like second- and third-rank doctrines within Orthodoxy? So even like with—so as you said, the Spirit will lead the Church into all truth. I imagine that you’re absolutely not like Jehovah’s Witnesses in a whole lot of ways. Obviously, Jehovah’s Witnesses are heretics for various reasons.” [laughter]

“But in the Jehovah’s Witness system they all seem to agree on every single minutia no matter who you meet within.”

“Oh no. There’s lots of—we have a term called the theologoumena. The toll houses, for example.”

“Yeah, I’ve heard different things about that.”

“Yeah. I mean toll houses are mentioned in our liturgical works. They are actually in our hymns. The interpretation of what a toll house is—knock yourself out. Whichever way you want to go.

“You want to believe that dogs go to heaven? Go ahead. There are arguments for and against these kinds of things. But the core doctrines and the core moral way of life is not negotiable.”

“Yeah. So can I just say—I wasn’t being offensive with you. I shouldn’t have used the Jehovah’s Witness example because—”

“No, I don’t think you’re offensive. Like we said, I’m not a snowflake. I didn’t even take that to be offensive.”

“Okay, good. I realize how that didn’t come across how I meant it.”

“No, I get it. I get it. The thing is that we believe things that are core—like the Creed, but more than the Creed. Obviously, I’m a priest. We believe that there’s grace in the priesthood. We believe that God appoints priests to officiate and therefore the Holy Spirit comes down upon the gifts and changes them into the Body and Blood of Christ. All these things are dogmatic, and they are certain and they are not negotiable in terms of are you an Orthodox Christian.

“But other things—you know, there’s a Russian idea that if you say Psalm 90—which is great, you’d probably know it as Psalm 91—it’s a great psalm about warfare, about spiritual warfare, about demons. There are some priests that will say, ‘Say that psalm forty times a day and this will happen.’ It’s like, no. If you want to say it forty times a day, fine. I’d rather say forty psalms a day rather than Psalm 90 forty times.

“And there are just all these kinds of things. I remember when I was young, in one of my churches, when the priest would yawn, he would immediately cross himself over his mouth. I said, ‘What are you doing?’ He said, ‘So

the demons can't come in.' It's like—duh. If you're open to demons they're going to come in through your nose or whatever. They don't need your open mouth."

"So, there are all these quaint things. Everybody has quaint things. But the core moral way of life—the phronema, the life of the Church, the mind of the Church—is true. All the little stuff I don't care about.

"But I don't really like this idea of big-T and little-t traditions. We have to be careful about that. Different customs—maybe they have lamb on Pascha, maybe they have something else. Maybe they have different customs about how they make a monastic or how a wedding is conducted. There are differences. But fundamentally the mind of the Church is the same."

"Yeah. I mean you probably would disagree with this, being an Orthodox priest, but from my own experience in the Protestant faith I have never been to a Protestant church—whether Presbyterian, Anglican, evangelical, Baptist, or whatever—where we have disagreed on the fundamentals."

"Now there are caveats to that. You might go to one Baptist church, and they would say that Mary is not the Theotokos. And obviously that is a serious error. But if I was to press them and say, 'Do you not believe that Jesus is God?' or 'Do you think He has two persons rather than two natures?' they would obviously say no, He has two natures. So even though they articulate it in a way that I would say is wrong and dangerous by denying the Theotokos, when it boils down to it, they would agree that Jesus is God and man, two natures, not two persons. Does that make sense?"

"It makes sense what you're saying, but I don't agree with it in terms of—I think there's a cacophony of beliefs. That's what I experienced when I was going to my Campus Crusade meetings. People would say, 'Okay, you believe in baptism?' 'Oh, you think it's a symbol.' 'Oh, you think it's necessary for salvation.' That's a big difference, right?

"Or the Eucharist. Obviously if you're hanging around Episcopalians and Presbyterians and others, they're going to have some core beliefs that are basically the same. And they're not going to say that the Eucharist is the Body and Blood of Christ—although I think Anglicans kind of say that."

"Yeah."

"And Episcopalians?"

"They can say it."

"Okay."

"So, there's a lot of difference in beliefs in my opinion. What you experienced—I understand that you've experienced pious Protestantism, if we can use such a term, because there aren't really Protestants anymore. You're not protesting. You just are what you are.

"But obviously you care. You read the Scriptures. You try to love your God and love your fellow man, follow the commandments, all those things. But really the lukewarmness of so-called Christianity is pretty evident, isn't it? Now you can make Christ be anything you want, because 'love is love,' right?"

"Yeah. That obviously is a huge problem."

"Yeah, that's definitely a huge problem. And is there a sense in which—and you can push back and say that I've got this wrong, so that's fine—I have one friend in particular who's married to a Romanian woman, and

he's a pastor in the Protestant tradition, and he was saying how in Romania a lot of the Orthodox believers are very different from the Orthodox guys like you and others that we see online. He was sort of saying that in Romania they really don't know Christ genuinely, that it really is just about the saints and other things, and they just don't know Him. Is that a fair pushback? I'd love to hear your thoughts on that."

"I completely agree with you. I completely agree with you. I was in Greece some time ago, and I think it was in October, and we were in Athens. Actually, we didn't plan to be in Athens, but we had a boat cancelled because of a strike. So here we are, and God has me in a square in Athens, and this woman approaches me with her Bible-only stuff, and she first asked like a question. And she was so enmeshed in her narrative she couldn't hear anything."

"Yeah. She was sorry about that."

"Well, I'm not sorry about it, because what it's done is caused literally hundreds of thousands, if not millions, of people to become aware of Orthodoxy. So, she's been an apostle for Orthodoxy. Sort of like Caiaphas. I'm not saying she's Caiaphas, now. But you know, Caiaphas said, 'It is good that one man die for the good of the people.' And indeed, it was good." [laughter] "Right? So, he was a prophet too. He just didn't get any credit for it."

"So, I pray for Sarah. Sarah has obviously come about her belief because of trauma, and she believes what she believes, and she has a narrative, etc., etc. But in Greece, absolutely—Greece has this incredible holiness. I've met people in Greece that are incredibly holy. Also people that are completely clueless and think in terms of, you know, they have to wear the cross as an amulet, or they have to pray to a certain saint if they have a knee problem, but a certain saint for a foot problem, and all this garbage. And they don't go to church. Churches are empty to a large extent. Same thing in Russia, same thing in Romania. Absolutely."

"But I would say as a polite pushback, you go to your average Baptist church in Texas, and most people have no clue what life is all about."

"Yeah, I'll take that. I haven't been to Texas, but I'll take that."

"Yeah. And I am though genuinely sorry how disrespected you were. That sort of was—"

"It's all good. It didn't bother me, actually. She was talking to me, and actually we had a little crisis at the moment because my wife had lost her phone in Athens, and it had her wallet and everything in it. Turns out we found it just a few minutes later. So, we're doing this and I'm talking to her and she just keeps going on and on, and I'm just realizing that she's just going to harangue me, right? And I used to tell her, 'All you're trying to do is convert me.' And it just was going to go on and on, so I had to find a way to extricate myself because we had stuff to do. That was the only thing that bothered me about the situation. I'm glad it happened. I think it was certainly in the providence of God for it to happen, and I'm glad it happened. I didn't feel accosted or anything like that. I just talked to her."

"You might be surprised to know that it also happens to me with evangelical street preachers as well. Whenever I go to Cambridge, I'm often stopped by one guy. He's like, 'If you were to die today, would you go to heaven or hell?' And I deliberately don't answer it in the way I know he wants me to answer because, as you said, they've got their script. They want me to say all of the right words. But it's not very genuine, is it?"

“No, it’s very proud too. I’m not saying they’re individually proud as a person, but their religion is proud. And I’m just not into it. ‘He who endures to the end will be saved.’ Since it’s not the end, I don’t know if I’ve endured all the way.”

“Sure. Yeah. I guess that would be one difference between us, wouldn’t it? I would say that having been justified, I will be sanctified and then eventually glorified—not because I’m good, not because I have any righteousness in myself, but because Christ has kept me and will keep me to the end. Yeah, that I guess we sort of differ on.”

“Can I get back to the Mary thing briefly?”

“Sure. It’s almost an hour. Are you doing okay?”

“I’m good, man. So that prayer then: Tear up the record of my many sins. Reconcile me to God. Make me worthy to stand. Deliver me from eternal torment.’ That bit I think worries me the most because Psalm 51—sin ultimately is against God, and so only God can forgive my sin. Only He can tear up the record of my debt. And so, to pray to Mary to forgive my sin and tear up that debt really troubles me. Of all those bits, that’s the bit that really sort of just makes—”

“I get it. I get it. It troubled me too. Like I said, it’s just a different mindset. For me, when I pray those prayers, I am asking the Theotokos to direct her prayers to her Son for me, a wretch, because her prayers are the—the effective and prayer of a righteous man availeth much. She’s much more righteous than me, so everything is in that prism, in that context. But I understand your reticence. I had it as well. But there’s something above that reticence: where is the Church? If the Church is true and the Church does it, then that must be true. That was always the way I approached everything.”

“Yeah. Right. So, are you saying then when you pray that prayer, you’re not really asking Mary to tear up the record of your sins? You’re asking her to take that to Jesus.”

“Exactly. Exactly. That Jesus would tear up the record of your sins.

Does sin offend God?

By the way, I don’t know if you have this doctrine or not. I understand it as somebody outside looking in that this is kind of a typical Reformed idea, that sin offends God, right?”

“Yes.”

“It’s a sin. It’s an offense to His justice, and sin keeps us from knowing God.”

“Yes.”

“But that’s because we get dark. What happened to Adam and Eve? Just in our Lenten readings, in our lectionary today, we were reading about the Fall in the Garden, and how the serpent says, ‘Hey, you know, if you eat this fruit, you become like God.’ Then she looks at it. ‘That looks good.’ And she eats it. And then what happens? When God is walking in the Garden, she’s afraid of Him, right? She and Adam are afraid. They make fig leaves for clothing because they know they’re naked now. And they’re afraid of God. What’s changed? God has not changed. They’ve changed. Sin made them dark.

“And we believe absolutely—it’s dogmatic—that if Adam and Eve had said, ‘We sinned. We did something terrible. Forgive us,’ they would have been forgiven and rectified and brought back to their state where they would eventually reach perfection. But they didn’t do that. And because of that, God did not punish them. You can see that language in the Scripture, but He didn’t punish them. He banished them from the Garden because in the Garden they would be eternal and they wouldn’t die, and who wants to live forever as a sinner? So, they had to learn the hard way to be able to come fully back to God.

“So, it was corrective, just like a doctor lances a boil. He doesn’t do it to cause you pain. He does it to get rid of infection and incidentally causes you pain, right? So, God does not punish us. I know that language is present, but men are the kind of people that punish. Justice for us is killing the person who killed my family, but that’s not justice, that’s revenge. God is not offended with us. The idea that God’s offended with us—what an idea.

“Instead, when we sin, we are further from God. We’re darker. We can’t understand Him. We’re afraid of Him. Not afraid of Him like the fear of God, but afraid of Him like the trembling, scared fear of a sinner. So, we don’t have this idea that God is offended by our sin. We have the idea that sin is offensive to our being. It’s toxic to what we should be. And that’s a big difference, really.

“And yet we use language that’s very similar. You could find language—if you go to the Lenten Triodion, you’ll find stuff that you love for sure, because you’ll find stuff that’s very much about the sinfulness of man and ‘don’t cast me to hell,’ all this terminology that could be a footnote in Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God for sure. But we don’t look at God as angry, nor believe Him to be angry, nor do we believe Him to be offended with sin. He is a loving Father who wants to bring us to perfection. And if we sin, then we’re like Adam and Eve: we hide in the Garden, right? Even though God hasn’t changed one bit. That’s a huge difference.

“So, all of our prayers, including the ones that you as a Reformed person would go, ‘Oh, that’s exactly right up my alley. That’s exactly the way we talk too’—those prayers, we might be talking like you’re talking, but we’re saying it in a different concept, right? I don’t believe God is angry with me. I don’t believe God has ever been angry with me. I believe that I’ve been often, daily, hourly terrible, and yet God loves me.”

“I have like a boatload of questions for that, but we might have to move on from that. But the Psalms will sometimes say, you know, God is angry with the wicked all the time. I do not believe God is angry with me—or you, if anyone is united to Christ by faith. I don’t believe God is angry with me if I do some sort of stupid sin tonight. It’s not like I have to come in and out of this anger and love. No. Jesus even says in John 15:9, ‘As the Father has loved Me, so have I loved you.’”

“Mhm.”

“So, this waterfall of amazing love that we have stepped into by grace is always upon those who believe. But to the unbeliever, would you not say God is angry with them at all in any sort of sense?”

“Oh no. No. God is not angry at all. Now the unbeliever might experience God’s love as anger, the wrath of God. But certainly, after death, a person who is opposed to God—then after death, the illustration I use is the sun. So, if you go to the beach and you go running and playing on the beach and you’re out there for six hours and you get a really terrible sunburn, at the end of the day your skin really hurts. The sun was beautiful. It was wonderful. The next day you don’t go out in the sun because even through a T-shirt the warmth of the sun makes your skin hurt, right? What’s changed? Not the sun. You’ve changed. Your skin is now damaged. So, a person in

the presence of the love of God who hates God or is opposed to God in their pitiful way, well, it'll be like being sunburned in the sun."

The Eucharist

"So, can you tell us a little bit about why the Eucharist is so special?"

"Oh," "it's like, say something in French. There's so much. Well, we take John chapter 6 extremely literally: 'Unless you eat My Body and you drink My Blood, you have no life in you.' And for us, salvation is an inner change, right? And we take in the Body and Blood of Christ and are changed in an interior way with interior grace, that we can't fully—we can't understand grace at all, really, but we can understand the effects of grace. So, partaking of the Eucharist is actually completely central to our faith, completely central to it, in every possible way.

"That gives it very little praise. I don't even know how to say how important the Eucharist is. But definitely the Lord said, 'Unless you eat My Body and you drink My Blood, you have no life in you.' And so, we take that very seriously. That's a very strict statement. So, we're going to do it. We're going to do it.

"And the crowds are scandalized. And rather than Jesus saying, 'Oh, no, no, no, I was just speaking symbolically,' He doubles down, triples down."

"Exactly. I like that you say that, man."

"You're being a crummy Protestant right now." [laughter] "Because, you know, I believe this is magisterial Reformed theology."

[laughter]

"Because that—to me the pushback proves the doctrine, right?"

"Yeah. Yeah. Yeah."

"Yeah. I agree. So, I'm sorry. I wish I could say more to you about the Eucharist. I don't really know how to expound on it, because it's just—you say Jesus in a special way, and He meets us in a real special way. What we say is His Body and Blood, and we don't bother with, you know, like you said, all this metaphysics. We don't bother with that.

"Now, does it clearly look like bread and wine? Yes, of course it does. But it's His Body and Blood. If Jesus can raise the dead, including four days dead, if Jesus can create the world," [laughter] "if Jesus can be raised from the dead by His own power, I think He can make bread and wine into His Body and Blood. So, we just believe it. That's all there is to it.

"And there are all kinds of stories and things where the Eucharist has appeared to be flesh for people that didn't have faith and things like that. But we believe. I mean, I'd prefer to be the believer that Jesus referred to when Thomas—He said to Thomas, 'Blessed are you because you've seen and believe. Blessed are those who've not seen and they believe.' So, I do not see the Body and Blood of Christ in the chalice, right? I see bread and wine, but I believe it to be. And belief is really a weak word. I know it to be."

“Sure. Whereas we would say that it is bread and is Body, and it is wine and is Blood. You wouldn’t quite be saying that.”

“No. I haven’t read everything that the holy Fathers have written about it. I would say—that’s a no, I wouldn’t say that. I would prefer to say it is the Body and Blood of Christ and that’s all there is to it.”

Does Orthodoxy teach there is no salvation outside the institution? What happens to Catholics or Protestants like me?

“Okay. So, one final question: does Orthodoxy teach there is no salvation outside the institution? What happens to Catholics or Protestants like me? Are we pretty much in for it? What are your thoughts on that?”

“Well, I know that the Orthodox Church is the true Church, and I know that it’s been revealed to me, and I know that if I don’t do what’s been revealed to me, I’ll go to hell. I know that with all of my heart. As far as what other people—what’s been revealed to them and what they’re responsible for and how God will judge them—we do not enter an opinion about them. So, shall we say, we are agnostic about that. We don’t say anything about it. They’re outside the Church. Let God judge them. God’s going to judge them anyway whether you let Him or not. And God is perfect. God is full of love. Actually, that’s wrong to say it that way. God is love. He’s not just full of love. He is love.

“And therefore, we don’t judge those outside of the Church. The Lord talked about those who know are beaten with more stripes and those who know less are beaten with fewer stripes, right? So, I don’t judge people with their sexual behaviors or other things. I judge the behavior, right? Absolutely, because I believe all aberrant behaviors, whether they’re sexual or not, bring us further from God. Absolutely. Whether it’s completely our fault or 90% our fault or 100% our fault, it doesn’t matter. All of it brings us further from God. But I don’t judge people as far as how much they are really trying. I don’t know. How much am I trying, you know?

“So, for people outside the Church—let me, I found a quote and I’ll read it because I think it’s St. Theophan the Recluse who said such a nice thing. Let’s see here. You know, whenever I do these things, I always make notes and then I never look at them.” [laughter] “It’s kind of interesting. Okay. Okay. So here it is. I’ll look at it for the first time.

““You ask, “Will the heterodox be saved?” Why do you worry about them? They have a Savior who desires the salvation of every human being. He will take care of them. You and I should not be burdened with such a concern. Study yourself and your own sins. I will tell you one thing, however. Should you be an Orthodox and, possessing the truth in its fullness, betray Orthodoxy and enter a different faith, you will lose your soul forever.”

“We cannot say that all”—this is from another quote— “we cannot say that all heterodox are lost. God desires all to be saved. If someone through ignorance belongs to a non-Orthodox confession yet seeks God sincerely and lives according to conscience, God may guide him in ways known to Himself. We don’t say God will. We don’t say absolutely positively. But we say God is God. That’s the way we leave it.

“Some people might consider that to be a weak position—probably a lot of ortho bros. I am not an ortho bro.” [laughter] “People have called me based before. I get mad when people call me based. I don’t like all that stuff. But this kind of ultra-legalism does not belong in Christianity.

“What you see online—for the ortho bros—yeah, I can’t say that I see a whole lot of it because, you know, I have a life. But yeah, I have seen things about it, etc. And yes, a lot of times these are pretty much young men mostly who really just have their own problems. I have actually heard of some ortho bros at some conferences, and I learned from people that they were drinking and smoking and smoking dope, and like most young men they had a problem with porn. I mean, they could expound about Orthodoxy and judge people like you. ‘You’re a bad guy because you’re not Orthodox enough for me.’ But they couldn’t control their own lives. They didn’t have any nepsis, any watchfulness, right? It’s just—okay, you know. We have to guard ourselves.”

“Yeah, I guess Pharisees.”

“Yeah. Although I think the Pharisees—they were full of arrogance, right? They were full of this arrogance. And I’m not so sure it was because they were developmentally stunted. I think that your average ortho bro is developmentally stunted. Psychologically stunted. The Pharisees, they were just bad guys. They were just bad people, right?”

“Yeah. Arrogant, horrendous people.”

“Yeah. You know.”

“Well, Father Seraphim, thanks so much for joining. I really appreciate it. It’s been really enjoyable and good.”

“We can do it again sometime if you would like.”

“That would be good. How can people find you online?”

“Well, our website is orthodox.net, and then our YouTube presence is @orthodoxnet. So orthodoxnet all together, and the website is orthodox.net. I would say we’re more active on YouTube and on Instagram than on anything else right now. I haven’t written many articles lately, etc., etc. But we are putting out videos all the time—no, not articles—videos all the time, sermons, catechesis, etc.

“You mentioned you saw what I said: don’t look at the Epstein files. I mean that with all my heart. If you don’t guard your heart, you’re going to have those images. One of those has gone over a million views.”

“So that’s good because Paul says to think about what is true and good and beautiful, and you know—”

“Yeah. Well, if you think of what is bad, if you encounter bad things, even if you do them accidentally, you can have repercussions in your soul. If you encounter them purposefully with idle curiosity, it’s such trouble. Now, there might be prosecutors, there might be lawyers, there might be whatever, that look at the unredacted files, and they’re going to have trouble, but they’re doing it for a reason. And I’m not so sure that there’s a prosecutor that’s going to prosecute anybody, myself, but that’s my personal opinion because this is at the highest places and this is highly demonic, and to think that we can just prosecute this or something like that, I just don’t think it’s at all possible. But even if so, even if people are trying to do that, or policemen who are working in vice units and dealing with the most horrendous crimes, they get counseling for that stuff because that stuff is horrendous and horrible. They go home to their wife, right? And they go home to their

children. And they go home to their daughter who's twelve when they just did a case with a twelve-year-old girl, right? So, you don't want to put that stuff in your head unless you must put it in your head to do your job.

"And I don't want to look at it. Somebody mentioned to me something about the Epstein files, and before I could stop them, I learned some piece of information, and it was like—it's so horrendous. It's so disgusting. It's so horrible. I just can't stand it."

"Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. Well, thanks so much for being with me, and thanks to those who are listening as well. Make sure you like and subscribe."

"And tell me how I get to you because I was looking for you, buddy. I couldn't find you. I really was."

"Reformed Pastor Clips, and you'll find me."

"Okay. Okay. All I can tell you as a parting shot, I would say if you become a really Reformed pastor, you become Orthodox." [laughter]